PSC 326: War and International Security

Summer 2025

Min Cho (mincho@buffalo.edu)

Office hours: Mondays & Thursdays 4pm-5pm (Except for Juneteenth; held June 20 instead). Please use this link (here) to sign up. A zoom link will be provided once you sign up. If the week's schedule is filled up, please email me to schedule a separate appointment.

Course Description

This course aims to provide you with the basic theoretical and empirical grounds for understanding war and international security. The course discusses various determinants of war and security, including but not limited to power, political institutions, economics, international organizations, nuclear weapons, gender, and environment. It also discusses the just war theory and the impact of war on human rights.

Assessment

6 Weekly quizzes (45%)

- 18 questions each
- Questions will cover materials from both the readings and lecture that week.
- These quizzes are open book but you are not allowed to consult each other.
- Lowest quiz grade will be dropped.

2 Movie reflections (10%)

- 1-2 pages, double-spaced. Use Times New Roman 12pt and 1-inch margins.
- Write assuming your reader watched the movie; do not include any summary. Tell me what your thoughts are and how it relates to what you read and learned

Final paper (30%)

- 4-5 pages, double-spaced. Use Times New Roman 12pt and 1-inch margins.
- Write a paper that connects a real world issue related to any of the topics covered in this class. The paper should:
    - Briefly summarize using less than 1 page what the issue is
    - Make connections with the theories and empirical results from the course
    - Make policy recommendation and support your argument with the theories and empirical results from the course
- Please submit your topic for approval by 10pm on June 12 (5%)

Final paper presentation (15%)

- Record a 10-minute presentation with slides (12%). The presentation will be graded on both the content and the presentation itself (i.e. slides, speech, etc.).
- Comment on 3 of your classmates' presentations (3%). Each comment should have at least 3 bullet points, each consisting of 2 or more sentences. Be kind and constructive. The comment could be on both the content and the presentation of it.

Extra credit

- 3 extra points for posting to the thread 'meet your classmates.' Tell us something about yourself like your hobbies, your favorite class you've taken at UB, or what kind of foods you like.
- 1 extra point for an additional comment you make on your classmates' presentations.

Schedule

Lecture opens every Wednesday at 10pm. The quiz covering that lecture closes on Sunday at 10pm.

Important Deadlines

June 1 10pm: Quiz 1 closes
June 1 11:59pm: Movie reflection 1 deadline
June 8 10pm: Quiz 2 closes
June 8 11:59pm: Movie reflection 2 deadline
June 12 10pm: Submit your paper topic
June 15 10pm: Quiz 3 closes
June 22 10pm: Quiz 4 closes
June 29 10pm: Quiz 5 closes
July 2 10pm: Final paper deadline
July 4 10pm: Final paper presentation deadline
July 6 10pm: Quiz 6 closes
July 7 10pm: Presentation comment deadline

Missed Deadlines

- There will be no makeup quizzes given.
- For movie reflections, final paper, and final presentation submitted late, 10% of the grade will be deducted each day.

Final Grades

Grade	Quality Points	Percentage
A	4.0	93.0% -100.00%
A-	3.67	90.0% - 92.9%
B+	3.33	87.0% - 89.9%
B	3.00	83.0% - 86.9%
B-	2.67	80.0% - 82.9%
C+	2.33	77.0% - 79.9%
C	2.00	73.0% - 76.9%
C-	1.67	70.0% - 72.9%
D+	1.33	67.0% - 69.9%
D	1.00	60.0% - 66.9%
F	0	59.9 or below

Course Materials
All required materials will be available on UB learns or through the UB library.

Accessibility Resources
If you have any disability which requires reasonable accommodations to enable you to participate in this course, please contact the Office of Accessibility Resources (716-645-2608) and also the instructor of this course during the first week of class. The office will provide you with information and review appropriate arrangements for reasonable accommodations, which can be found here.

Academic Integrity
When referencing any work of others, provide a citation. Failure to do so will constitute plagiarism. Any use of generative AI is prohibited in this class. Students must abide by the university's policies and procedures on Academic Integrity, available here.

Topics and Readings (readings must be completed before watching the lecture)

Week 1 (May 27-May 30)
Perspectives on the cause of war and international security
- Mingst and Arreguín-Toft. 2013. *Essentials of International Relations*. 252-259, 289-298

Cause of war
- Levy, Jack S. 1998. "The causes of war and the conditions of peace." *Annual Review of Political Science* 1 (1): 139–65.

Crisis bargaining
- Fearon, James D. 1995. "Rationalist explanations for war." *International organization* 49 (3):379-414.
- Reiter, Dan. "Exploring the bargaining model of war." Perspectives on Politics 1, no. 1 (2003): 27-43.

Watch The Fog of War

Week 2 (June 2-June 6)
Balance of power
- Kenneth N. Waltz. 1979. *Theory of International Politics*. Chapter 6

Security dilemma
- Jervis, Robert. "Cooperation Under the Security Dilemma." World Politics, vol. 30, no. 2, January 1978, p. 167-186.

Nuclear weapons and war
- Huth, Paul K. 1999. "Deterrence and international conflict: empirical findings and theoretical debates." *Annual Review of Political Science* 2 (1): 25–48.
- Waltz, Kenneth N. 2012. *Why Iran Should Get the Bomb: Nuclear Balancing Would Mean Stability. Foreign Affairs* (New York, N.Y.). Vol. 91. NEW YORK: Council on Foreign Relations.

Watch Dr. Strangelove

Week 3 (June 9-June 13)

Selectorate theory

- Bueno de Mesquita, Bruce, James D. Morrow, Randolph M. Siverson, and Alastair Smith. 2004. "Testing novel implications from the selectorate theory of war." *World Politics* 56 (3): 363-388.

Democratic peace

- Reiter, Dan. 2017. "Is Democracy a Cause of Peace?" *Oxford Research Encyclopedia of Politics*. Oxford University Press.
- Maoz, Zeev, and Bruce Russett. 1993. "Normative and Structural Causes of Democratic Peace, 1946–1986." *The American Political Science Review* 87 (3): 624–38

Diversionary theory

- Fordham, Benjamin O. 2017. "More Than Mixed Results: What We Have Learned From Quantitative Research on the Diversionary Hypothesis." *Oxford Research Encyclopedia of Politics*. Oxford University Press.

Week 4 (June 16- June 20)

Commercial peace

- Schultz, Kenneth A, M Levi, and N Rosenblum. 2015. "Borders, Conflict, and Trade." *Annual Review of Political Science* 18 (1): 125-45
- Gartzke, Erik. 2007. "The Capitalist Peace". *American Journal of Political Science* 51 (1): 166–191

Sanctions and war

- A CFR Backgrounder: What are Economic Sanctions? By Jonathan Masters. Found here

International organizations and war

- Keohane, Robert O. 1984. *After Hegemony*. Chapter 6
- Oneal, John R., Bruce Russett, and Michael L. Berbaum. 2003. "Causes of Peace: Democracy, Interdependence, and International Organizations, 1885-1992. *International Studies Quarterly* 47(3): 371-393.
- Boehmer, Charles, Erik Garzke, and Timothy Nordstrom. 2004. "Do Intergovernmental Organizations Promote Peace? *World Politics* 57(1): 1-38

Week 5 (June 23-June 27)

Gender and war

- Schwartz, Joshua A., and Christopher W. Blair. 2020. "Do Women Make More Credible Threats? Gender Stereotypes, Audience Costs, and Crisis Bargaining." *International Organization* 74 (4): 872–95
- Joslyn N. Barnhart, Robert F. Trager, Elizabeth N. Saunders and Allan Dafoe. 2020. "The Suffragist Peace." *International Organization* 74 (4): 633–70.
- Demeritt, Jacqueline H.R, Angela D Nichols, and Eliza G Kelly. 2014. "Female Participation and Civil War Relapse." *Civil Wars* 16 (3): 346–68.

Environment and war

- Gleditsch, Nils Petter. 2012. "Whither the Weather? Climate Change and Conflict." *Journal of Peace Research* 49 (1): 3–9.
- Koubi, Vally, NL Rosenblum, and M Levi. 2019. "Climate Change and Conflict." *Annual Review of Political Science* 22 (1): 343–60.

Week 6 (June 30-July 7)

War and morality

- Mingst and Arreguín-Toft. 2013. *Essentials of International Relations*. 283-289
- Lazar, Seth. 2017. "Just War Theory: Revisionists Versus Traditionalists." *Annual Review of Political Science* 20 (1): 37–54.

Changing norms

- Price, Richard. 1998. "Reversing the Gun Sights: Transnational Civil Society Targets Land Mines." International Organization 52 (3): 613-44.

War and human rights

- Bell, Sam R., K. Chad Clay, and Carla Martinez Machain. 2018. "U.S. Troop Deployments and Human Rights." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 61 (10): 2020–42.
- Balcells, Laia, Jessica A Stanton, M Levi, and NL Rosenblum. 2021. "Violence Against Civilians During Armed Conflict: Moving Beyond the Macro- and Micro-Level Divide." *Annual Review of Political Science* 24 (1): 45–69